INCH-POUND

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MILITARY SPECIFICATION

PEPPERS, GREEN, HALVES, STUFFED WITH BEEF AND RICE IN SAUCE, THERMOSTABILIZED, TRAY PACK

This specification is approved for use by all Departments and Agencies of the Department of Defense.

1. SCOPE

1.1 Scope. This specification covers green peppers stuffed with beef and rice in sauce, thermostabilized in tray pack cans for use by the Department of Defense as a component of operational rations.

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

2.1 Government documents.

2.1.1 Specifications, standards, and handbooks. The following specifications, standards, and handbooks form a part of this document to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise specified, the issues of these documents are those listed in the issue of the Department of Defense Index of Specifications and Standards (DODISS) and supplement thereto, cited in the solicitation (see 6.1).

SPECIFICATIONS

FEDERAL

PPP-B-636 - Boxes, Shipping, Fiberboard

Beneficial comments (recommendations, additions, deletions) and any pertinent data which may be of use in improving this document should be addressed to: U.S. Army Natick Research, Development, and Engineering Center, Natick, MA 01760-5014 by using the self-addressed Standardization Document Improvement Proposal (DD Form 1426) appearing at the end of this document or by letter.

AMSC N/A FSC 8940

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SPECIFICATIONS

FEDERAL

PPP-B-636 - Boxes, Shipping, Fiberboard

MILITARY

MIL-L-1497 - Labeling of Metal Cans for Subsistence Items
MIL-L-35078 - Loads, Unit: Preparation of Semiperishable Subsistence Items; Clothing, Personal Equipment and Equipage; General Specification For
MIL-C-44340 - Can, Tray Pack

STANDARDS

MILITARY

MIL-STD-105 - Sampling Procedures and Tables for Inspection by Attributes
MIL-STD-129 - Marking for Shipment and Storage
MIL-STD-900 - Bacterial Standards for Starches, Flours, Cereals, Alimentary Pastes, Dry Milks and Sugars Used in the Preparation of Thermo-stabilized Foods for the Armed Forces

(Unless otherwise indicated, copies of federal and military specifications, standards, and handbooks are available from the Naval Publications and Forms Center, (ATTN: NPODS), 5801 Tabor Avenue, Philadelphia, PA 19120-5099.)

2.1.2 Other Government documents, drawings, and publications. The following other Government documents, drawings, and publications form a part of this document to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise specified, the issues are those cited in the solicitation.

ENVIRONMENTAL PROTECTION AGENCY (EPA)

National Primary Drinking Water Regulations

(Copies are available from the Office of Drinking Water, Environmental Protection Agency, WH550D, 401 M Street, S.W., Washington, DC 20460.)

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE (USDA)

Institutional Meat Purchase Specifications (IMPS) for Fresh Beef, Series 100

(Copies are available from the Director, Livestock and Seed Division, Agricultural Marketing Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Room 2092, South Building, P.O. Box 96456, Washington, DC 20090-6456.)

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Meat and Poultry Inspection Regulations

(Copies are available from the Superintendent of Documents, U.S. Government Printing Office, Washington, DC 20402-0001.)

U.S. Standards for Condition of Food Containers

(Copies are available from the Chairman, Condition of Food Container Committee, Agricultural Marketing Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Room 0608, South Building, P.O. Box 96456, Washington, DC 20090-6456.)

U.S. Standards for Sweet Peppers

U.S. Standards for Grades of Tomato Paste

(Copies are available from the Director, Fruit and Vegetable Division, Agricultural Marketing Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Room 2077, South Building, P.O. Box 96456, Washington, DC 20090-6456.)

U.S. Standards for Milled Rice

(Copies are available from the Chief, Field Management Division, Standards and Procedures Branch, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Room 1661, South Building, P.O. Box 96456, Washington, DC 20090-6456.)

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES (HHS)

Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act and regulations promulgated thereunder (21 CFR Parts 1-199)

(Copies are available from the Superintendent of Documents, U.S. Government Printing Office, Washington, DC 20402-0001.)

2.2 Non-Government publications. The following documents form a part of this document to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise specified, the issues of the documents which are DOD adopted are those listed in the issue of the DODISS cited in the solicitation. Unless otherwise specified, the issues of documents not listed in the DODISS are the issues of the documents cited in the solicitation (see 6.1).

AMERICAN ASSOCIATION OF CEREAL CHEMISTS (AACC)

Approved Methods of the American Association of Cereal Chemists

(Application for copies should be addressed to the American Association of Cereal Chemists, 3340 Pilot Knob Road, St. Paul, MN 55121.)

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AMERICAN DEHYDRATED ONION AND GARLIC ASSOCIATION (ADOGA)

Official Standards and Methods of the American Dehydrated Onion and Garlic Association for Dehydrated Onion and Garlic Products

(Application for copies should be addressed to the American Dehydrated Onion and Garlic Association, 650 California Street, Suite 800, San Francisco, CA 94108.)

AMERICAN SOCIETY FOR TESTING AND MATERIALS (ASTM)

D 3330 - Peel Adhesion of Pressure-sensitive Tape

(Application for copies should be addressed to the American Society for Testing and Materials, 1916 Race Street, Philadelphia, PA 19103-1187.)

ASSOCIATION OF OFFICIAL ANALYTICAL CHEMISTS (AOAC)

Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analytical Chemists

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Association of Official Analytical Chemists, 1111 North 19th Street, Suite 210, Arlington, VA 22209.)

NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES

Food Chemicals Codex

(Application for copies should be addressed to the National Academy Press, 2101 Constitution Avenue, N.W., Washington, DC 20418.)

(Non-Government standards and other publications are normally available from the organizations that prepare or distribute the documents. These documents also may be available in or through libraries or other informational services.)

2.3 Order of precedence. In the event of a conflict between the text of this document and the references cited herein, the text of this document takes precedence. Nothing in this document, however, supersedes applicable laws and regulations unless a specific exemption has been obtained.

3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 First article. When specified (see 6.1), a sample shall be subjected to first article inspection (see 6.2) in accordance with 4.4.

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3.2 Ingredients. All ingredients shall be clean, sound, wholesome, and free from foreign material, evidence of rodent and insect infestation, extraneous material, off-odors, off-flavors, and off-colors.

3.2.1 Beef. The beef shall be from steers, heifers, or cows and shall be derived from any combination of carcasses, quarters, and any of the following recognizable primal and subprimal cuts or portions thereof: square-cut chucks, shoulder clods, chuck rolls, ribs, ribeyes, trimmed full loins, trimmed short loins, strip loins, sirloins, top sirloin butts, rounds, top rounds, peeled knuckles, outside rounds, and bottom rounds (heel out). Recognizable cuts are those which, when compared to IMPS cuts, have no more than a minor amount of lean, fat, or bone removed or included from an adjacent cut. A portion is a certified recognizable cut from which objectionable tissue, such as tendons or heavy connective tissue, has been removed. Tenderloins, rib fingers (intercostal meat), and any part of a rough cut may be excluded at the option of the contractor. The beef shall be in the fresh-chilled state and shall be in excellent condition; i.e., exposed lean and fat surfaces shall be of a color and bloom normally associated with the class and cut of meat, and typical of meat which has been properly stored and handled. Cut surfaces and naturally exposed lean surfaces shall show no more than slight darkening or discoloration due to dehydration, aging, or microbial activity. The fat shall show no more than a very slight discoloration due to oxidation or microbial activity. No odors foreign to fresh meat shall be present. Changes in color and odor characteristically associated with vacuum-packaged meat in excellent condition shall be acceptable. Also, the meat shall show no evidence of freezing, defrosting or mishandling.

3.2.1.1 Boning and trimming. The beef shall be boned and trimmed to remove objectionable material such as bone, cartilage, heavy connective tissue, etc. The boneless trimmed beef shall meet the limitations specified in tables I and II.

3.2.1.2 Handling and storage. Handling and storage of the boned and trimmed beef, prior to processing into the finished product, shall be in accordance with the following requirements:

a. Beef processed on the day of initial certification shall be maintained in the temperature range of 28° to 50°F (inclusive).

b. Holding in the fresh-chilled state for not more than 4 days after initial certification is permitted provided that the beef is maintained in the temperature range of 28° to 40°F (inclusive).

c. Holding in the frozen state for not more than 120 days after initial certification is permitted provided that the beef is:

- frozen to 0°F or lower within 72 hours after initial certication
- stored at 0°F or lower
- protected from freezer deterioration and damage
- stored in containers that are adequate to maintain product excellence

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d. Tempering/thawing of frozen beef shall comply with the following:

- Microwave tempering/thawing of frozen beef is permitted provided excellent condition of the beef, as determined by USDA, is maintained.
- the microwave tempering/thawing process shall not exceed 24 hours from time of removal of the beef from the freezer to further preparation.
- regardless of the process used, frozen beef shall be tempered/thawed to a temperature not to exceed 40°F.
- when a tempering/thawing process other than microwave is used, the time from the start of the tempering/thawing process (removal from freezer) to further preparation shall not exceed 96 hours.
- beef which has been tempered/thawed shall not be refrozen.

3.2.2 Tomato paste. Tomato paste shall be U.S. Grade A of the U.S. Standards for Grades of Tomato Paste. See formulation in 3.3.5 for required soluble solids content.

3.2.3 Worcestershire sauce. The Worcestershire sauce shall be a brown to dark brown liquid having a pleasant, tart, peppery fruit-spice flavor with a typical heavy viscosity. Titratable acidity, as acetic acid, shall be not less than 2.8 nor more than 3.8 percent.

3.2.4 Sugar. Sugar shall be white, refined, sucrose, liquid or granulated, cane or beet or both. The sugar shall comply with MIL-STD-900.

3.2.5 Salt. Salt shall be noniodized, white, refined, sodium chloride, with or without anticaking agents and shall comply with the purity standards for sodium chloride of the Food Chemicals Codex.

3.2.6 Onion, chopped, dehydrated. The dehydrated, chopped onion shall be fancy grade of the Official Standards and Methods of the American Dehydrated Onion and Garlic Association for Dehydrated Onion and Garlic Products.

3.2.7 Starch, waxy maize, modified. The starch shall be white, odorless, finely pulverized, modified waxy maize starch for use in thermostabilized foods and shall comply with MIL-STD-900. The modified starch shall demonstrate initial viscosity development in the temperature range of 140° to 170°F and a typical viscosity (be fully hydrated) at common retort temperatures. The starch shall resist breakdown at low pH, under shear stress, and under conditions of cold storage. The cooked modified starch slurry shall be bland with essentially no cereal or starch taste.

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3.2.8 Pepper, black, ground. Ground black pepper shall have been ground from the deep brown to black, deep-set, wrinkled, immature berries of Piper nigrum L. The ground pepper shall have a characteristic penetrating odor, a hot biting pungent flavor, and a light grey to speckled black-grey color. The ground pepper shall contain not less than 2.0 mL of volatile oil per 100 grams of ground pepper and shall be of such size that not less than 95 percent shall pass through a U.S. Standard No. 16 sieve.

3.2.9 Pepper, red, ground. Ground red pepper shall be derived from red, ripe fruit of Capsicum frutescens L. and shall possess the characteristic yellowish-red to red color with a perceptible sensation of pungency. It shall be uniformly ground to allow a minimum of 95 percent by weight to pass through a U.S. Standard No. 40 sieve and not less than 95 percent by weight to be retained on a U.S. Standard No. 60 sieve. The Scoville Pungency Value shall be not less than 30,000 units.

3.2.10 Rice, long grain, parboiled. Rice shall be parboiled, long grain, milled rice, U.S. No. 2 or better of the U.S. Standards for Milled Rice. The rice shall be of such varieties as Belle patina, Bluebelle, Bluebonnet, Lebonnet or similar varieties. The rice shall contain not more than 2 percent of kernels having white ungelatinized areas and not less than 10 percent or more than 15 percent moisture.

3.2.11 Peppers, green, sweet, fresh. Sweet green peppers shall be fresh, firm, medium size, 95 to 105 per bushel or crate. The peppers shall be U.S. No. 1 in accordance with the U.S. Standards for Sweet Peppers.

3.2.12 Water. Water used for ice making, formulation, and washing shall conform to the National Primary Drinking Water Regulations.

3.2.13 Preblended spice and seasoning mixture. Preblended spices and seasonings may be used. The spices and seasonings in the mixture shall comply with the requirements of this specification. The containers used for the spice and seasoning blend shall be labeled with each ingredient and the percentage of each ingredient in the blend. The ingredients shall be in the same proportions as specified in the ingredient formula.

3.3 Preparation and processing. Processing shall be on a continuous basis.

3.3.1 Beef preparation. The beef shall be prepared as follows:

a. Boned and trimmed beef which meets the requirements of 3.2.1.1 shall be further trimmed, if necessary, to assure compliance with finished product requirements.

b. The beef shall be ground through a plate with holes measuring 5/32 inch in diameter. Alternatively, the beef may be coarse ground initially through a plate having holes 1 inch in diameter followed by grinding through a plate having holes 5/32 inch in diameter.

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runs. The peppers shall be blanched 2 to 4 minutes in 190° to 200°F water, rinsed, and cooled in cold water. Each pepper half shall be uniformly filled with prepared stuffing to meet finished product requirements. Unless filled immediately after stuffing, the stuffed green pepper halves shall be maintained in the temperature range of 28° to 40°F for not more than 4 hours prior to filling into the tray pack can.

3.3.5 Sauce preparation. The sauce shall be formulated and prepared as follows:

Ingredient	Percent by weight
Water	73.98
Tomato paste (26 percent solids) 1/	21.88
Starch, modified	1.00
Sugar	2.10
Salt 2/	0.95
Pepper, red, ground	0.03
Pepper, black, ground	0.06

1/ If the specified tomato solids are not available, the tomato solids that are used must be calculated to bring the solid level to that specified.

c. The ground beef shall be held for not more than 24 hours in the temperature range of 28° to 40°F prior to stuffing preparation.

3.3.2 Rice preparation. The rice shall be soaked in room temperature water (approximately 70°F) until the rice has gained approximately 70 percent of its original weight. After soaking, the rice shall be placed in a cooler to lower the temperature to 40°F prior to mixing with the ground beef.

3.3.3 Stuffing preparation. The following ingredients shall be mixed to form the stuffing. The stuffing shall be filled immediately after preparation or cooled to an internal temperature of 28° to 40°F and held for not more than 4 hours prior to green pepper stuffing.

Ingredient	Percent by weight
Ground beef	71.53
Uncooked rice (soaked)	22.91
Salt	1.86
Worcestershire sauce	1.86
Onions, dehydrated, chopped	1.79
Pepper, black, ground	0.05

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3.3.4 Green pepper preparation and stuffing. The peppers shall be split in

2/ The total amount of salt in the sauce formula shall be adjusted as necessary to produce a product that complies with the finished product salt requirement.

NOTE: The following sauce preparation procedures were used in the development of this product. Alternative procedures may be used provided finished product requirements are met. (When alternative procedures are used, the time and temperature requirements specified for the prepared sauce are still applicable.)

a. The starch and part of the water shall be mixed to form a slurry.

b. The balance of the water and remaining ingredients shall be mixed together and heated to approximately 140°F.

c. The starch slurry shall be added and the final mixture heated, stirring constantly, to a temperature of 180° to 190°F, and held in this temperature range for approximately 5 minutes.

d. The volume of the sauce shall be adjusted with water prior to filling to compensate for evaporation loss during heating and holding.

e. The sauce shall be maintained in the temperature range of 150° to 180°F for not more than 4 hours prior to filling into tray pack cans.

3.4 Tray pack filling and sealing. Each tray pack can (see 5.1.1) shall be filled with product to conform to the finished product requirements and to the following requirements:

a. Each can shall be hermetically sealed under a vacuum established by a processing authority and specified in the scheduled process so as to ensure compliance with the finished product requirement (see 3.6.q).

b. The filled and sealed tray pack cans shall be in the retort process within 2 hours after sealing.

3.5 Tray pack thermoprocessing. The filled and sealed tray pack cans shall be thermostabilized by retorting until a sterilization value (F_o) of not less than 6 has been achieved.

3.6 Finished product requirements. The finished product shall comply with the following requirements:

a. There shall be no foreign material such as, but not limited to, dirt, insect parts, hair, wood, glass, or metal.

b. There shall be no foreign odor or flavor such as, but not limited to, burnt, scorched, stale, sour, rancid, or moldy.

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c. There shall be no color foreign to the product.

d. The total weight of cartilage, coarse connective tissue, section of tendons or ligaments, and glandular material, collectively, in a can shall be not more than 1 ounce.

e. No individual can shall contain a bone piece measuring 0.3 inch or more in any dimension.

f. Texture of the stuffed peppers shall not be dry, tough, rubbery, or mushy.

g. Each can shall contain 12 stuffed pepper halves.

h. Each stuffed pepper half shall weigh not less than 6.2 ounces.

i. Each stuffed pepper half shall show no evidence of separation of the stuffing from the pepper half when removed from the tray pack can.

j. Sauce consistency shall not be lumpy or excessively thick or thin.

k. The average net weight shall be not less than 106 ounces.

l. No individual can shall contain less than 104 ounces of product.

m. The average fat content shall be not greater than 10.0 percent.

n. The fat content of any individual tray pack shall be not less than 8.0 percent nor greater than 12.0 percent.

o. The salt content of any individual tray pack shall be not less than 0.5 percent nor greater than 1.2 percent.

p. The product shall show no evidence of excessive heating (materially darkened or scorched).

q. Filled, sealed, and retorted cans shall show evidence of proper vacuum as determined by concavity of the can lid (see 4.5.6).

3.6.1 Palatability. The finished product shall be equal to or better than the approved preproduction sample (see 6.1) in palatability and overall appearance.

3.7 Plant qualification. The beef component and the finished product shall originate and be produced, processed and stored in plants operating under the Meat and Poultry Inspection Regulations of the U.S. Department of Agriculture.

3.8 Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act. All deliveries shall conform in every respect to the provisions of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act and regulations promulgated thereunder.

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4. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS

4.1 Contractor's responsibility. Inspection and acceptance by the USDA shall not relieve the contractor of obligation and responsibility to deliver a product complying with all requirements of this specification. The contractor shall ensure product compliance prior to submitting the product to the USDA for any inspection.

4.2 Inspection and certification. Product acceptability shall be determined by the USDA. The USDA will determine the degree of inspection necessary to ensure compliance with the requirements of this specification.

4.3 Classification of inspections. The inspection requirements specified herein are classified as follows:

a. First article inspection (see 4.4)
b. Quality conformance inspection (see 4.5)

4.4 First article inspection. When a first article is required (see 6.1), it shall be inspected in accordance with the quality assurance provisions of this specification and evaluated for overall appearance and palatability. Any failure to conform to the quality assurance provisions of this specification or any appearance or palatability failure shall be cause for rejection of the first article.

4.5 Quality conformance inspection. Unless otherwise specified, sampling for inspection shall be performed in accordance with MIL-STD-105.

4.5.1 Component and material inspection. In accordance with 4.1, components and materials shall be inspected in accordance with all the requirements of referenced documents unless otherwise excluded, amended, modified, or qualified in this specification or applicable purchase document.

4.5.1.1 Beef examination for condition and cut. All beef shall be examined in either the bone-in or boneless state for conformance to the condition and cut requirements in 3.2.1. Cuts initially examined in the boneless state shall be in the form of whole boneless recognizable cuts or portions thereof. Any nonconforming beef shall be rejected.

4.5.1.2 Boned and trimmed beef examination. After boning and trimming and prior to any further processing or to any freezing, the beef shall be examined for the defects listed in table II. The lot size expressed in terms of pounds shall be declared to the Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS) agent by the contractor. However, the AMS agent reserves the right to declare as a lot a portion of a declared lot, if, in his or her opinion, that portion may be out of compliance with any requirement. The sample unit shall be a minimum of 12 pounds of adjacent boneless beef. The sample size shall be as specified in table I. If all or a portion of the sample unit falls within a larger cut, the

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entire cut shall be examined. Failure of the beef to meet the acceptance criteria as indicated in table I shall be cause for rejection of the lot. Except for beef rejected because of freezing, defrosting, or not being in excellent condition, the beef may be reworked by the contractor and reoffered for examination. For reexamination, the sampling plan used shall be the one in table I designed for the next larger lot size than the one under which the lot was initially rejected. Beef shall not be reexamined more than one time.

TABLE I. Sampling plan for boned and trimmed beef

Lot size (pounds)	Sample size (No. of sample units)	Defect categories			
		Major		Minor	
		AC	RE	AC	RE
500 or less	20	2	3	5	6
501 to 1200	32	3	4	7	8
1201 to 3200	50	5	6	10	11
3201 to 10000	80	7	8	14	15
10001 to 38000	125	10	11	21	22
Reinspection lots of 10001 to 38000	200	14	15	21	22

TABLE II. Boned and trimmed beef defects 1/ 2/

Category		Defect
Major	Minor	
101		Presence of popliteal, prescapular, prefemoral or any exposed lymph gland measuring 0.5 inch or more in any dimension.
102		Presence of blood clot measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension.
	201	Presence of blood clot measuring 0.5 inch or more but less than 1.0 inch in any dimension.
103		Presence of bruise measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension.
	202	Presence of bruise measuring 0.5 inch or more but less than 1.0 inch in any dimension.

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TABLE II. Boned and trimmed beef defects 1/ 2/ (cont'd)

Category		Defect
Major	Minor	
104		Presence of bone measuring 0.3 inch or more in any dimension.
105		Presence of cartilage measuring 0.5 inch or more in any dimension.
106		Presence of backstrap measuring 1.0 inch or more in one dimension and 0.2 inch or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
	203	Presence of backstrap measuring 0.5 inch or more but less than 1.0 inch in one dimension and 0.2 inch or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
107		Presence of heavy connective tissue (for example, on the surface of the outside round adjacent to the knuckle, along the skin surface of the strip loin, or the gracilis membrane) measuring 2.0 square inches or more.
	204	Presence of heavy connective tissue (for example, on the surface of the outside round adjacent to the knuckle, along the skin surface of the strip loin, or the gracilis membrane) measuring 0.5 square inches or more but less than 2.0 square inches.
	205	Presence of heavy connective tissue on lower edge of short plate or flank.
	206	Presence of heavy connective (abdominal tunic) tissue on the flank measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension.
	207	Presence of membranous portion of diaphragm or membranous covering from skirt, flank, or abdominal section of short plate measuring 3.0 square inches or more.

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TABLE II. Boned and trimmed beef defects 1/ 2/ (cont'd)

Category		Defect
Major	Minor	
108		Presence of knuckle cover.
109		Presence of kidney, pizzle eye, prepubic tendon, thymus gland, or hanging tender measuring 1.0 inch or more in one dimension and 0.2 inch or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
	208	Presence of kidney, pizzle eye, prepubic tendon, thymus gland, or hanging tender measuring less than 1.0 inch in one dimension and 0.2 inch or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
	209	Presence of calcified (scratchy) periosteum measuring 2.0 square inches or more.
	210	Presence of shank, clod, knuckle, or bottom (outside) round with tendinous end showing less than 75 percent lean tissue on a cross-sectional cut surface.
	211	Presence of dehydrated surface measuring 1.0 square inch or more.
	212	Presence of discolored meat (including blood discolored neck meat) measuring 1.0 square inch or more.
	213	Presence of exposed blood vessel measuring 1.0 inch or more in any dimension.
	214	Presence of cod, udder, kidney, or pelvic fat.

1/ Determination of wholesomeness and acceptability of product with respect to the presence of foreign material (for example, glass, dirt, insect parts, hair, wood, metal) shall be made by a Meat and Poultry Inspection Operations employee.

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2/ Evidence of freezing or defrosting or product not in excellent condition shall cause rejection of the lot.

4.5.1.3 Ingredient and component examination. Conformance of ingredients and components to identity, condition, and other requirements specified in 3.2 shall be certified by the ingredient supplier or ingredient manufacturer, and compliance shall be verified by examination of pertinent labels, markings, U.S. Grade certificates, certificates of analyses, or other such valid documents acceptable to the inspection agency. If necessary, each ingredient shall be examined organoleptically or inspected according to generally recognized test methods, such as the standard methods described in the Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analtyical Chemists and in the Approved Methods of the American Association of Cereal Chemists, to determine conformance to the requirements. Any nonconformance to an identity, condition, or other requirement shall be cause for rejection of the ingredient or component lot or of any involved product.

4.5.2 In-process examination. In-process examination shall be performed to determine conformance to the preparation, processing, can interior coating, filling, sealing, and packing requirements. Any nonconformance revealed by actual examination or by review of records of time, temperature, and formulation or of other valid documents shall be cause for rejection of the involved product.

4.5.3 Tray pack inspection. The inspection lot shall include only tray packs produced in one workshift. The USDA reserves the right to separate the inspection lot into smaller inspection lots.

4.5.3.1 Net weight inspection. Randomly select 30 filled and sealed tray pack cans from the inspection lot and weigh separately. Subtract the average tare weight (determined by randomly selecting and weighing 30 of the empty tray pack cans and lids used in preparing the product and dividing the total weight by 30) from the weight of each tray pack in the sample. The results shall be reported to the nearest 1 ounce. If the average net weight is less than 106 ounces or if the net weight of any individual can is less than 104 ounces, the lot shall be rejected.

4.5.3.2 Product inspection. The sample size shall be as indicated by the double sampling plan specified in table III. The tray pack cans shall be selected at random from the lot. The tray pack cans shall be heated in accordance with heating instructions on the can label, opened, and inspected for the defects in table IV.

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TABLE III. Double sampling plan for product inspection 1/

Lot size (cans)	Sample size (cans)	Cumulative sample	Acceptance number	Rejection number
0 to 3200	8	---	0	2
	8	16	1	2
3201 to 35000	13	---	0	3
	13	26	3	4

1/ a. If no defects are found in the first sample, the lot shall be accepted.

b. If the number of defects found in the first sample equals or exceeds the rejection number, the lot shall be rejected.

c. If the number of defects found in the first sample exceeds the acceptance number but is less than the rejection number, the second sample shall be inspected. Defects found in the first and second samples shall be combined and if the number of defects in the cumulative sample equals or exceeds the rejection number, the lot shall be rejected.

TABLE IV. Product defects 1/ 2/

Category	Defect
Major	
101	Total weight of cartilage, coarse connective tissue, section of tendons or ligaments, and glandular material, collectively, in a can is more than 1 ounce.
102	Presence of bone piece measuring 0.3 inch or more in any dimension in an individual can.
103	Less than 12 stuffed pepper halves.
104	Stuffed pepper half in a can weighs less than 6.2 ounces.

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TABLE IV. Product defects 1/ 2/ (cont'd)

Category	Defect
Major	
105	Texture of stuffed peppers dry, tough, rubbery, or mushy.
106	Sauce consistency lumpy or excessively thick or thin.
107	Separation of stuffing from pepper half when removed from tray pack can.
108	Product shows evidence of excessive heating (materially darkened or scorched).

1/ The presence of foreign material (for example, glass, dirt, insect parts, hair, wood, metal), foreign odor or flavor (for example, burnt, scorched, moldy, rancid, sour, stale), or foreign color shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

2/ Product not equal to or better than the approved preproduction sample in palatability and overall appearance shall be cause for rejection of the lot. (This comparison shall be performed only when deemed necessary by an AMS agent.)

4.5.3.3 Fat and salt content testing. Nine tray packs shall be randomly selected from the lot and distributed as follows:

- Three for laboratory analyses
- Three for submission to the contractor
- Three for retention by an AMS agent as reserve samples.

The three tray packs for laboratory analyses shall individually be tested for fat and salt content in accordance with the Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analytical Chemists, Chapter: Meat and Meat Products, except that preparation of the samples shall be as follows. The three unopened tray packs shall be gently warmed in a water bath to melt fat adhering to the inside of the cans. The cans shall be opened and the entire contents of each can shall be separately blended in a Waring blender or equivalent. The test results shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 percent. Any test failure shall be classified as a major defect. The lot shall be rejected if any of the following defects occur:

a. The average fat content of the three tray packs is greater than 10.0 percent.

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b. The fat content of any individual tray pack is greater than 12.0 percent or less than 8.0 percent.

c. The salt content of any individual tray pack is less than 0.5 percent or greater than 1.2 percent.

Analysis of reserve samples at the request of the contractor shall not be permitted unless the original laboratory analysis indicated that the involved lot will be rejected because of noncompliance with the fat or salt content requirement. When the reserve samples are analyzed, the analyses for both fat and salt shall be made and will be considered final. Unused reserve samples shall be returned to the contractor for inclusion in subsequent lots.

4.5.4 Can condition examination. Examination of filled and sealed tray pack cans shall be in accordance with the United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers, except that inspection for labeling shall be in accordance with 4.5.4.1. In addition, the following defect shall be classified as a critical defect and shall be cause for rejection of the lot:

Bare metal exposed on exterior of can (see 5.1.1).

4.5.4.1 Can label examination. Labels shall be examined for defects in accordance with MIL-L-1497 (see 5.4) except, for self-adhering labels, the following additional defects shall apply:

Major: Label torn or scratched so as to obliterate any of the markings.

Minor: Air bubbles under label.
Label not properly adhered to can, for example, label raised or peeled back from edges or corners.

4.5.4.2 Label adhesive examination. When self-adhering labels are used, the adhesive shall be tested in accordance with ASTM D 3330.

4.5.5 Can closure examination. Can closures shall be examined visually and by teardowns in accordance with the can manufacturer's requirement and 21 CFR, Part 113, Subpart D, or 9 CFR, Part 318, Subpart G, as applicable. Any nonconformance based on observation of can seam teardowns or on record of can seam teardowns shall be classified as a major defect and shall be cause for rejection of any involved product.

4.5.6 Vacuum examination. Cans shall be allowed to cool to 75° ± 5°F, held for at least 24 hours after sealing, and then examined for vacuum retention. To examine, lay a straight edge in the center of the lid along the length of the tray pack. Both ends of the straight edge shall touch the lid at the inside edge of the double seam. There shall be a visible gap between the straight edge and the lid for the entire distance of the label panel. Using a shorter straight edge, the same procedure shall be used across the width, in the center

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of the tray pack can. One measurement shall be made when examining a ribbed lid; lay the straight edge between the two center ribs along the length of the can. The inspection lot shall include only tray packs produced in a single shift on a single sealing machine. The sample size shall be 50 cans. Any nonconformance shall be classified as a major defect and shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

4.5.7 Shipping container examination. Shipping containers shall be examined for defects in assembly, closure and reinforcement (when applicable), in accordance with PPP-B-636. In addition, the following defects shall be classified as follows:

Major: National stock number, item description, contract number, or date of pack markings missing, incorrect, or illegible.
Reinforced with other than nonmetallic strapping or tape.
Dimensions of pads not as specified.
Interior packing with fiberboard liner or pads not as specified.

Minor: Other required markings missing, incorrect, or illegible.
Arrangement or number of cans not as specified.

4.5.8 Unit load inspection. Inspection of unit loads shall be in accordance with the quality assurance provisions of MIL-L-35078.

5. PACKAGING

5.1 Preservation. The product shall be preserved in accordance with level A.

5.1.1 Level A. One hundred and six ounces of food product shall be filled into a tray pack can conforming to MIL-C-44340 and sealed and thermoprocessed as specified in 3.4 and 3.5. There shall be no evidence of denting, scuffing, scratching, or abrasion of exterior can coating resulting in exposure of bare metal (see 4.5.4).

5.2 Packing. The product shall be packed in accordance with level A, B, or C as specified (see 6.1).

5.2.1 Level A packing. Four cans of product, preserved as specified in 5.1, shall be packed in a snug-fitting fiberboard box, constructed and closed in accordance with style RSC-L or HSC-L with a HSC full depth cover, grade V2s of PPP-B-636. The cans shall be packed flat, four in depth within the box, with the first two cans placed with the lids together and the next two cans with the lids together. The inside of each box shall be provided with a box liner and five fiberboard pads fabricated of grade V3c fiberboard. The height of the box liner shall be equal to the full inside depth of the box (+0 inch, -1/8 inch). Flute direction of the box liner shall be vertical. The pads shall be placed between the cans and on the top and bottom of the stacked cans. The pad dimensions shall be not less than 1/8 inch of the full length and width dimensions of the box. Each box shall be reinforced with nonmetallic strapping

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or pressure-sensitive adhesive filament-reinforced tape in accordance with the appendix of PPP-B-636. Shipping containers shall be arranged in unit loads in accordance with MIL-L-35078 for the type and class of load specified (see 6.1) except that the unit load shall consist of 48 boxes with 12 boxes per course and four courses per load with all courses having the same pattern so as to create columnar stacking. When unit loads are strapped, strapping shall be limited to nonmetallic strapping, except for type II, class F loads.

5.2.2 Level B packing. Four cans of product, preserved as specified in 5.1, shall be packed as specified in 5.2.1, except the box shall be constructed of grade V3c, V3s or V4s fiberboard.

5.2.3 Level C packing. Four cans of product, preserved as specified in 5.1, shall be packed in a snug-fitting fiberboard box, constructed and closed in accordance with style RSC-L, class domestic, grade 275 of PPP-B-636. The cans shall be packed flat, four in depth within the box, with the first two cans placed with the lids together and the next two cans with the lids together. The inside of each box shall be provided with a box liner and five fiberboard pads. The height of the box liner shall be equal to the full inside depth of the box (+0 inch, -1/8 inch). Flute direction of the box liner shall be vertical. The pads shall be placed between the cans and on the top and bottom of the stacked cans. The pad dimensions shall be not less than 1/8 inch of the full length and width dimensions of the box and shall be fabricated of the same material as the box.

5.3 Unit loading. When specified (see 6.1), the product, packed as specified in 5.2.2 or 5.2.3, shall be arranged in unit loads in accordance with MIL-L-35078 for the type and class of load specified except that the unit load shall consist of 48 boxes with 12 boxes per course and four courses per load with all courses having the same pattern so as to create columnar stacking. When unit loads are strapped, strapping shall be limited to nonmetallic strapping, except for type II, class F loads.

5.4 Labeling. Each tray pack can shall be labeled in accordance with MIL-L-1497 and with the following:

- Official establishment number (for example, EST 38) or a three letter code identifying the establishment.
- Lot number 1/
- Production shift number 1/
- Retort identification number 1/
- Retort cook number 1/

1/ The lot number shall be expressed as a four digit Julian code. The first digit shall indicate the year of production and the next three digits

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shall indicate the day of the year (Example, March 19, 1989 would be coded as 9078). The Julian code shall represent the day the product was packaged and processed. Sub-lotting (when used) shall be represented by an alpha character immediately following the four digit Julian code. Following the four digit Julian code and the alpha character (when used), the other required code information shall be printed in the sequence as listed above.

In addition, the name of product shall be marked, stamping is permitted, on one 1001 by 200 side of the can. The labeling shall be legible when examined as specified in 4.5.4 after preparation of product in accordance with heating instructions. Paper labels are not permitted. Cans shall show the following statements:

TO HEAT IN WATER: Submerge unopened can in boiling water. Simmer gently 40 -45 minutes. Avoid overheating (can shows evidence of bulging).

CAUTION: Use care when opening as pressure may have been generated within the can.

TO HEAT IN OVEN: Either punch several holes in lid of can or open can in usual manner leaving the loose lid in place. Place in a 350°F oven 35 - 40 minutes.

WARNING: Do not place unopened can in oven. This may cause the can to burst.

YIELD: Serves 12 portions of 1 stuffed pepper half each.

As an alternate labeling method, a preprinted self-adhering 0.002 inch thick clear polyester label printed with indelible black ink may be used. Self-adhering labels shall be applied after retorting. Pressure-sensitive adhesive shall require no preparation prior to application. Labels shall tack quickly and adhere without curling or breaking. The adhesive shall have a minimum adhesion of 60 ounces per inch width when examined as specified in 4.5.4.2. When self-adhering labels are used, the tray pack cans shall be labeled with the Julian code and a product code prior to retorting.

5.5 Marking.

5.5.1 Shipping containers. In addition to any special marking required by the contract or purchase order, shipping containers shall be marked in accordance with MIL-STD-129.

5.5.2 Unit loads. Unit loads shall be marked in accordance with MIL-L-35078. In addition, the following precautionary marking in capital letters larger than other markings shall be included:

CAUTION: DO NOT STACK PALLETS IN TRANSIT OR MORE THAN TWO HIGH IN STORAGE, UNLESS PALLET RACKS ARE USED.

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6. NOTES

(This section contains information of a general or explanatory nature that may be helpful, but is not mandatory.)

6.1 Aquisition requirements. Acquistion documents must specify the following:

a. Title, number and date of this specification.
b. Issue of DODISS to be cited in the solicitation, and if required, the specific issue of individual documents referenced (see 2.1.1 and 2.2).
c. When a first article is required (see 3.1, 4.4, and 6.2).
d. Provisions for approved preproduction samples (see 3.6.1 and 6.2).
e. Level of packing required (see 5.2).
f. Type and class of unit load when unit loading is required (see 5.2.1 and 5.3).

6.2 First article. When a first article is required, it shall be inspected and approved under the appropriate provisions of FAR 52.209. The first article should be a preproduction sample. The contracting officer should specify the appropriate type of first article and the number of units to be furnished. The contracting officer should also include specific instructions in acquisition documents regarding arrangements for selection, inspection, and approval of the first article.

6.3 Appropriate level of pack. Based on conditions known or expected to be encountered during shipment, handling and storage of the specific item being procured, the procuring activity should select the appropriate level of pack in accordance with the criteria established in AR 700-15/NAVSUPINST 4030.28/ AFR 71-6/MCO 4030.33A/DLAR 4145.7.

6.4 Subject term (key word) listing.

Canned foods
Combat field feeding
Food processing
Operational rations
Shelf stable

Custodians:
Army - GL
Navy - SA
Air Force - 50

Preparing activity:
Army - GL

(Project 8940-0557)

Review activities:
Army - MD, TS
Navy - MC
DP - SS

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STANDARDIZATION DOCUMENT IMPROVEMENT PROPOSAL

(See Instructions – Reverse Side)

1. DOCUMENT NUMBER	2. DOCUMENT TITLE
MIL-P-44373	Peppers, Green, Stuffed with Beef and Rice in Sauce, Thermostabilized, Tray Pack

3a. NAME OF SUBMITTING ORGANIZATION	4. TYPE OF ORGANIZATION *(Mark one)*
	☐ VENDOR
	☐ USER
b. ADDRESS *(Street, City, State, ZIP Code)*	☐ MANUFACTURER
	☐ OTHER *(Specify)*: _____

5. PROBLEM AREAS

a. Paragraph Number and Wording:

b. Recommended Wording:

c. Reason/Rationale for Recommendation:

6. REMARKS

7a. NAME OF SUBMITTER *(Last, First, MI)* – Optional	b. WORK TELEPHONE NUMBER *(Include Area Code)* – Optional
c. MAILING ADDRESS *(Street, City, State, ZIP Code)* – Optional	8. DATE OF SUBMISSION *(YYMMDD)*

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NOTE: This form may not be used to request copies of documents, nor to request waivers, deviations, or clarification of specification requirements on current contracts. Comments submitted on this form do not constitute or imply authorization to waive any portion of the referenced document*(s)* or to amend contractual requirements.

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